

MY457: Seminar 4 Guiding Questions

2026-03-17

Paper:

Paper: Goyal, T. and Sells, C., 2024. Descriptive Representation and Party Building: Evidence from Municipal Governments in Brazil. *American Political Science Review*, 118(4), pp.1840-1855.

Guiding Questions:

1. General

- What is the primary causal question of interest?
- What is the treatment? What is the outcome? Are there secondary causal questions too?
- Explain the causal inference problem. Why can the authors not just collect data on the presence of women mayors and their outcomes of interest, and run bivariate regressions?

2. Measurement and research design

- What is the unit of analysis / what are the observations?
- What is the level of treatment assignment?
- What is the assignment mechanism? Explain it in simple terms, and how it motivates the research design.
- What are the key assumptions underpinning the design? How do the authors assess the credibility of their design? Is this convincing? Can you think of any other tests that might be useful?

3. Interpretation

- Is this a fuzzy or a sharp design?
- What is the estimand targeted by this design? Is that a useful quantity?
- Do you have any concerns about the quantity targeted by this design? Think carefully about what the research questions are, what the causal concept is, what the causal variable is, and how it is assigned.
- What comparisons are being made? You might consult appendix B in the supplementary material, and consider what you imagine the data might look like.